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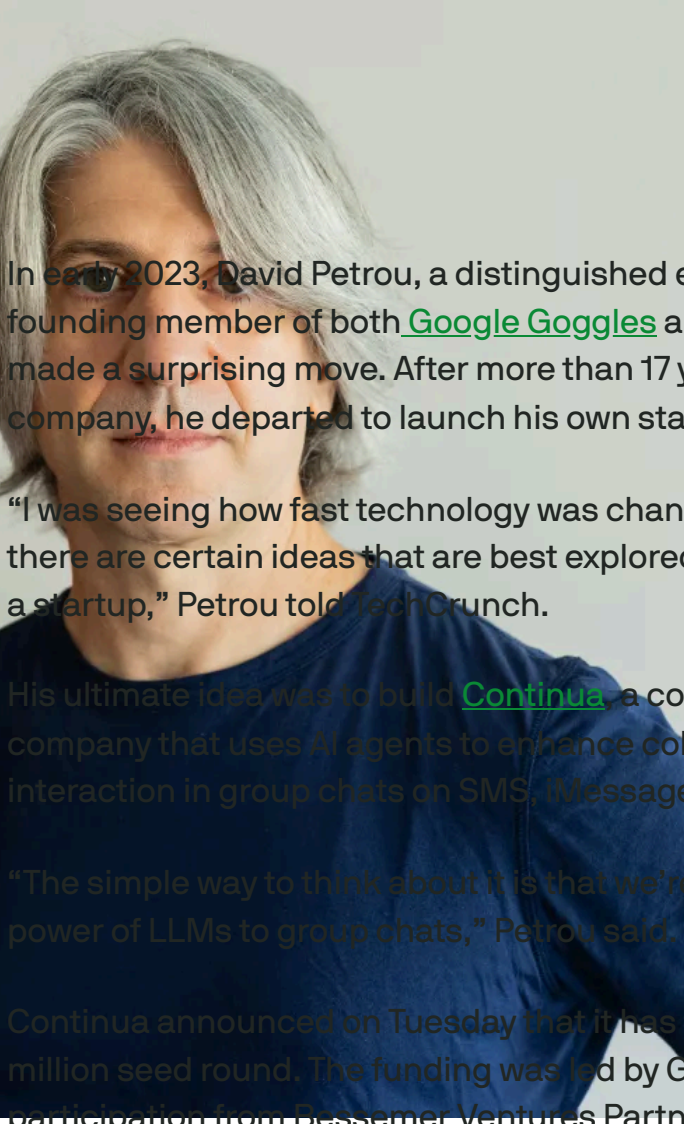
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VENTURE



Google vet raises \$8M for Continua to bring AI agents to group chats



In early 2023, David Petrou, a distinguished engineer and founding member of both [Google Goggles](#) and Google Glass, made a surprising move. After more than 17 years at the company, he departed to launch his own startup.

“I was seeing how fast technology was changing, and I felt there are certain ideas that are best explored in the context of a startup,” Petrou told TechCrunch.

His ultimate idea was to build [Continua](#), a consumer-facing company that uses AI agents to enhance collaboration and interaction in group chats on SMS, iMessage, and Discord.

“The simple way to think about it is that we’re bringing the power of LLMs to group chats,” Petrou said.

Continua announced on Tuesday that it has raised an \$8 million seed round. The funding was led by GV, with additional participation from Bessemer Ventures Partners and a group of angel investors.

IMAGE CREDITS: CONTINUA

When developing Continua, Petrou noticed that people would interact with ChatGPT or another LLM, and then would copy and paste what they learned into their group conversation.

“If you and I are planning a trip, or if we’re trying to figure out what to have for dinner, or what movie to watch, all of these things can be facilitated by an LLM participating in a group chat with us,” Petrou said.



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Continua claims its AI agents can reduce group chat chaos by joining conversations and offering helpful information only when it's needed.

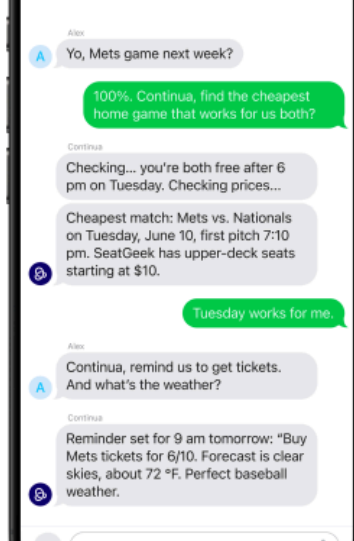
As the group discusses projects and common plans, Continua can automatically set reminders, launch polls, add calendar invitations, or generate Google documents with checklists and to-do lists.

If a user forgets details from the group chat, such as the meeting time or location, they can simply direct message Continua to privately ask for the information.

At first glance, Continua may seem like a straightforward application of AI, but Petrou says that getting LLMs to participate in a conversation with multiple humans is a rather complex technical problem. Since most AI models are designed for conversations between a single person and a single assistant, Continua had to fine-tune LLMs to understand the dynamics of group chat discussions.

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For instance, group members do not need Continua to respond to everything they write.

“You want the agent to have social intelligence,” Petrou said. He added that they had to “break the LLM’s brain” to naturally integrate the AI into conversations.

Users can invoke Continua when they need its help or tell the agent to “hang back” if it’s chiming in too often.

Users can get started with Continua by adding its phone number to a group SMS or its username to a Discord chat.

While several companies, including Meta and the startup Hey Umai, offer AI agents for conversations, Petrou insists that Continua is most suitable for group interactions.

Erik Nordlander, a general partner at GV, said his firm invested in Petrou even before the concept of Continua’s group chat AI had fully taken shape. “David is a really brilliant engineer, someone who’s been working with AI since before it was the hot thing.”

According to Nordlander, Continua has several potential paths to profitability. The agent is already assisting with event planning and trip booking, which he suggested they could charge for in the future.

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Marina Temkin

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Marina Temkin is a venture capital and startups reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining TechCrunch, she wrote about VC for PitchBook and...

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IMAGE CREDITS: PARADIGM

STARTUPS



Why Paradigm built a spreadsheet with an AI agent in every cell

Rebecca Szkutak — 8:00 AM PDT · August 18, 2025

Anna Monaco has been building AI agents since before the term “AI agents” was even a thing. After building numerous chatbots, she started looking for other types of interfaces that made sense for AI agents and landed on spreadsheets.

“I had this personal pattern, and I noticed that a lot of other people had this pattern, of putting very important CRM data in spreadsheets just because it was the most flexible thing,” Monaco told TechCrunch. “But it was actually a pain to maintain. There’s so much manual work involved. So [I] just went down this rabbit hole of building a product for myself and wanted to reimagine what a spreadsheet could look like with the full power of LLMs.”

The result was [Paradigm](#), an AI-powered spreadsheet equipped with more than 5,000 AI agents. Users can assign different prompts to individual columns and cells, and individual AI agents will crawl the internet to find and fill out the needed information.

Paradigm works with AI models from Anthropic, OpenAI, and Google’s Gemini, Monaco said, and supports model switching.

“We want to support every single model because we want our users to be able to have the highest reasoning outputs when they need it, but also the cheapest outputs,” Monaco said. “It’s just a constant cycle of evaluating different models, working closely with model providers to make sure our limits are high enough, and then giving some of that power to our users.”

The company launched a small closed beta preview in late 2024 and has been iterating on the product using customer feedback. Paradigm attracts users ranging from consultants to sales professionals and finance folks and operates on a subscription model with tiers based on usage. Paradigm counts the consulting firm EY, AI chip startup Etched, and AI coding company Cognition as early customers.

Paradigm is now releasing its product to the public and announcing that it raised a \$5 million seed round led by General Catalyst. The company has raised \$7 million to date. Monaco said the funding will go toward executing on the company’s “extremely aggressive product roadmap.”

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“The interesting thing that happened when we fundraised is some people we pitched just kept on using and paying for the product,” Monaco said. “I think that was a cool part of it. We found a lot of value from it internally and our investors, not even just our investors — other investors that we talked to — are still using it.”

Paradigm isn't the only company looking to give spreadsheets an AI upgrade. [Quadratic](#), which has raised more than \$6 million in venture funding, is a 3-year-old startup with a similar goal. Legacy companies like Google and Microsoft are also adding AI tools to their spreadsheet applications.

Monaco said that she doesn't really consider the competition because Paradigm doesn't think of itself as an AI-powered spreadsheet. She said she thinks of it as a new AI-powered workflow that happens to be in the familiar form of a spreadsheet but won't necessarily stay that way forever.

“What I'm seeing in the most popular AI products now is this fine balance between present and future,” Monaco said. “How do you build something that is really powerful and generates a lot of value now but also sets you up really well for the future? That's the question that I asked myself a year ago when I was starting the company.”

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Rebecca Szkutak

Senior Reporter, Venture | [in](#)

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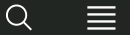


FUNDRAISING



Eight Sleep raises \$100M to expand its AI-powered sleep tech

Kate Park — 3:00 AM PDT · August 19, 2025



with this round, Eight Sleep has raised roughly \$200 million total, Pitchbook estimates. It previously raised an \$86 million Series C in 2021 by investors who assigned it a [\\$500 million post-money valuation](#). Eight Sleep said its valuation has doubled since its last round, but didn't disclose specifics.

"If we successfully execute our AI roadmap, launch internationally, and develop condition-specific interventions, achieving unicorn status will naturally follow," Alexandra Zatarain, co-founder and CMO of Eight Sleep, told TechCrunch.

Eight offers smart mattresses that integrate software and AI to track and enhance sleep quality. Its flagship product, Pod, offers features like measuring sleep stages, heart rate, breathing patterns, and movement. Using these insights, it automatically adjusts temperature, elevation, and firmness. It can also detect snoring and automatically elevate the base in response, according to the company.

The company has generated more than \$500 million in Pod sales, expanded its revenue tenfold since launching the product in 2019, and collected insights from over one billion hours of recorded sleep data, it says.

Eight, which employs just over 100 full-time staff, is now expanding beyond the Pod with its Sleep Agent, an AI-driven system that leverages large language models to create thousands of digital twins for each user and predict outcomes, with the goal of optimizing nightly recovery. This approach shifts sleep technology from reactive tracking to proactive, personalized intervention, said Zatarain.



with an AI agent in every cell
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The sleep tech market features a range of competitors, from wearable devices such as Oura, Fitbit, and Apple, to medical-focused companies like ResMed, as well as smart mattress and sleep surface makers, including Sleep Number and ChiliSleep.

Eight's core differentiator, Autopilot, "builds a personal blueprint from night one, then adapts continuously, accounting for seasonality, travel, stress, training, illness, or even a bad night before. And it works independently for each side of the bed," Zatarain said.

The startup plans to use the new funding to accelerate its growth in the medical sector, building on the Pod's health-monitoring capabilities. With the introduction of Health Check, the system can monitor cardiovascular and respiratory patterns with up to 99% accuracy without the need for wearable devices, according to the company.

"We're not replacing your doctor, but we are giving you nightly, high-accuracy health monitoring so you can act early if trends shift. Over time, this data can complement medical care," Zatarain said.

Eight's recently launched [Hot Flash Mode](#) employs AI-driven cooling to relieve menopause symptoms. It is also working on contactless solutions for sleep apnea. The company is pursuing FDA approval and will utilize the Pod's real-time biometric monitoring to deliver personalized interventions.

Eight Sleep currently ships to over 30 countries—including Canada, the UK and EU nations, Australia, Mexico, and the UAE—and is now planning to expand into China. The CMO told TechCrunch that China, as one of the world’s largest consumer markets, is seeing a rise in a health-conscious middle class that prioritizes sleep and overall wellness.

Regarding sensitive health data, Zatarain said the company complies with each locale’s regulations, including for data storage.

“Privacy is foundational. All data is encrypted, never sold, and fully private. We comply with GDPR and CCPA, and unlike many devices, we don’t use microphones. Our biometric sensors are embedded in the bed surface — no wearables, no invasiveness, just passive, high-accuracy insights,” Zatarain said.

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Kate Park

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Kate Park is a reporter at TechCrunch, with a focus on technology, startups and venture capital in Asia. She previously was a financial...

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AI crawler Firecrawl raises \$14.5M, is still looking to hire agents as employees

Julie Bort — 4:00 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

Firecrawl's co-founder and CEO Caleb Pfeffer knew the exact moment he found the investor to lead his Series A.

He was in a coffee meeting with Nexus Venture Partner's Abhishek Sharma at the Blue Bottle in San Francisco's South Park (a favorite VC haunt). While describing the future of the company, he was gesturing so animatedly that his chair tipped over.

IMAGE CREDITS: FIRECRAWL

"I actually fell out of my chair. And Abhishek, as a great Investor does, caught the chair and me as I was falling," Pfeffer described with a laugh. That felt like a symbol for how the founder/investor relationship is supposed to work. "I think that was a clear signal that he was the right partner."

On Tuesday, Firecrawl announced a Series A led by Nexus with participation from Shopify CEO Tobias Lütke and existing investor Y Combinator.

Firecrawl offers a popular open-source web crawler for developers and AI agents, with a commercially supported version available through API. It's used by 350,000 developers, has nearly [50,000 stars](#) on GitHub and its notable customers include Shopify, Replit, and Zapier as well as "some of the largest hedge funds in the world," Pfeffer told TechCrunch. And, he says, the company is already profitable.

The startup also just released an API that supports search and will soon add support for natural language prompts, as co-founder and CTO Nicolas Silberstein Camara noted.

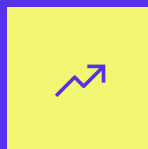
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Peffer, who co-founded Firecrawl in 2022 with Camara and CMO Eric Ciarla, said gaining Lütke as an investor was “the best kind of validation.”

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founder’s request

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They landed him through a gutsy email after discovering the Shopify founder had signed up to try their product through their self-service portal.

“We saw his email come in,” Peffer said. The Firecrawl crew immediately emailed him to welcome him as a customer, but got no response. Two months later, some Shopify folks contacted Firecrawl for an enterprise contract. So Peffer took his shot and emailed Lütke again, mentioning they’d love for him to participate in their upcoming round.

This time, Lütke responded with compliments about their product. He was in.

While AI web crawlers have [a somewhat dubious reputation these days](#), mostly due to bad actors [that ignore robot.txt files](#), they are also a necessary part of the burgeoning AI world. AI trains on the web, [agents need to access web pages to perform their duties](#), and enterprises need personalized crawlers to consume their own websites for training and operations.

The Firecrawl founders also hope to help address the frustrating parts of their industry. They are working on tools to help website owners, publishers, and other content creators

“get paid when AI uses their content. We think this is the way it should be,” Peffer said.

While there have been lots of efforts around this idea from big names like [Adobe and Getty](#) as well as startups [like Bria](#), [Calliope Networks](#), and others, Peffer feels that Firecrawl has an edge because it’s already working with those who are scraping data.

“We already have one side of the marketplace,” he said. “What we want to do is just connect that side of the marketplace to the website owners, the publishers.”

Interestingly, Firecrawl also went viral a few months ago for reasons that have little to do with their open source tool. They had posted an [ad to the YC job board looking to hire an AI agent as an employee for a \\$15,000 salary](#) – perhaps the first job ad for an agent employee, ever.

That job search didn’t yield an agent worth hiring, so Firecrawled upped the budget to up [\\$1 million to hire several agents and the developers who built them, and tried again](#). Applicants flooded in, Peffer said, but the company hasn’t yet hired any. The founders realized that evaluating and managing wanna-be agent employees is a job in itself. So now they are looking for an AI chief of staff.

Firecrawl’s Peffer will [be on stage at Disrupt in October](#) to discuss all that he’s learned in a session that covers the pros and cons of hiring AI agents as early employees.

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Julie Bort

Venture Editor | 

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